The Planners

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The Planners

This revision guide to Boey Kim Cheng's poem 'The Planners', from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1, Part 4 anthology, includes:

- **Overview**: a detailed breakdown of the 'The Planners', including its possible meanings and interpretations
- **Writer's methods**: an exploration of Boey Kim Cheng's poetic methods
- **Understanding the text**: an exploration of Cheng's ideas, themes and possible messages in 'The Planners'

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Remember, even though the poem will be printed on your exam paper, you are still expected to demonstrate your thorough knowledge of it via references to the poem, as well as the use of accurate, relevant quotations. You need to show the examiner that you understand both the poem and the question.

Pay particular attention to the focus of the question (the theme you are being asked to explore). Then, as you re-read the poem on the exam paper, highlight and annotate key words and phrases directly relevant to the question's focus. You should structure your response and your use of quotations in chronological order, and ensure that you respond to every section of the poem.

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is vital that you understand what it is about. This section includes:

- The poem in a nutshell
- A "translation" of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Cheng's intention and message

'The Planners' in a nutshell

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

always a good idea as it **inhibits** creativity and leaves no room for inspiration.

'The Planners' breakdown

Lines 1–2

"They plan. They build. All spaces are gridded,

filled with permutations of possibilities."

Translation

- The speaker comments on the meticulous planning and construction of urban places and how the "spaces" are filled with possibilities

Cheng's intentions

- The speaker begins by acknowledging the actions of 'The Planners', who **meticulously** plan and construct urban spaces:
  - The verbs "plan" and "build" imply that their actions are intentional and purposeful, highlighting the intentions of the Planners in shaping the landscape
- The speaker describes all the spaces as being "gridded", suggesting a uniform and **regimented** layout that is characteristic of urban planning:
  - The use of the word "gridded" conveys a sense of order, implying that the Planners intend to impose a systematic arrangement on the environment
- The first line uses **caesura** as it is structured in short sentences with full stops:
  - The could reflect the monotony and uniformity of the urban landscape that they are building by imitating building blocks
  - It also reinforces the theme of control and manipulation that is inherent in urbanisation
- In the second line, the speaker suggests that these spaces are "filled with permutations of possibilities", which highlights the potential for variation and diversity within the seemingly uniform urban landscape

Lines 3–6

"The buildings are in alignment with the roads

which meet at desired points

linked by bridges all hang

in the grace of mathematics."

Translation

- The speaker provides a detailed description of the landscape created by the Planners

Cheng's intentions

- The phrase "the buildings are in alignment with the roads" suggests a deliberate effort to create a sense of order and coherence:

planning
- The roads are described as meeting "at desired points", which indicates that their layout is designed carefully in order to create seamless connections within the city
- The speaker emphasises the idea of connectivity by noting that the roads are "linked by bridges" which "all hang":
    - The bridges may symbolise a sense of elevation, which re-emphasises the idea that the Planners have overcome physical obstacles to create an environment that is connected

- It is worth noting that Cheng uses positive language to describe the landscape in the first six lines of stanza one:
    - Cheng has used words such as "possibilities", "desired" and "grace" to suggest that everything is working seamlessly and how it should be

- A lexical field of mathematics has been used in the first six lines to reflect how the Planners use mathematics in order to build the urban landscape
- Cheng uses a mixture of concrete nouns such as "buildings", "roads" and "bridges" and abstract nouns such as "possibilities" and "grace" in order to highlight how everything is working harmoniously and how the future is full of opportunities for growth

Lines 7–9

"They build and will not stop.

Even the sea draws back

and the skies surrender."

Translation

- The speaker's tone now shifts from positive to negative as they highlight the Planners' relentless pursuit and determination to keep building

Cheng's intentions

- The speaker claims that the Planners "build and will not stop", which suggests an ongoing process of construction and development:
    - The phrase "will not stop" highlights the **relentless** pursuit of growth and expansion and the determination of the Planners in shaping the landscape according to their vision

- The personification of the sea moving back and the skies having to "surrender" implies that 'the Planners have triumphed over the forces of nature:
    - It is implied that the natural world was at war with manmade materials such as concrete and steel, but that nature has lost and is forced to retreat
    - The use of **sibilance** in the last two lines could reflect the sinister nature of what has happened and create a sense of foreboding and evil as the "sea draws back" and the "skies surrender"

- It is worth noting that the first stanza does not really make reference to any people or animals who live in the city:

city, which is portrayed as a detached, lifeless object that has forced any sign of life to withdraw

Lines 10–14

"They erase the flaws,

the blemishes of the past, knock off

useless blocks with dental dexterity.

All gaps are plugged

with gleaming gold."

Translation

- The speaker describes how the Planners conceal any "flaws" and "blemishes" with medical precision

Cheng's intention

- The speaker describes how the Planners "erase the flaws, the blemishes of the past", suggesting a deliberate effort to eradicate any imperfections:
  - The use of the word "erase" implies a thorough and deliberate process of removal, highlighting the Planners' desire to create a pristine and flawless urban landscape
  - This reflects a sense of perfectionism and control, as the Planners seek to **impose** their vision of order and beauty upon the urban environment

- Cheng uses an extended metaphor of dentistry in this stanza by mentioning how the Planners "knock off useless blocks with dental dexterity":
  - This imagery conveys a sense of precision and skill in the Planners' actions
  - The phrase "dental dexterity" suggests a level of expertise that a dentist performing an operation would possess

- The imagery of the gaps being "plugged with gleaming gold" suggests a sense of extravagance:
  - The use of the word "gleaming" conveys a sense of brightness and artificiality and the choice of "gold" as a filling suggests a desire to create a sense of luxury and **grandeur**
  - It suggests that the Planners will spare no expense in the pursuit of their goals

- Cheng has used language that contains hard consonant sounds such as "dental dexterity" and "plugged with gleaming gold" to create a **cacophony** of disordered and unpleasant sounds that mimic drilling:
  - This adds to the negative portrayal of the Planners as they are presented as harsh and ruthless individuals with their own agenda

Lines 15–20

"The country wears perfect rows

of shining teeth.

Help me understand

They have it all so it will not hurt,

so history is new again."

Translation

- The speaker continues to use the extended metaphor of dentistry to describe what the Planners do in order to keep control and continue their expansion

Cheng's intention

- The speaker metaphorically describes the houses as "perfect rows of shining teeth":
  - This imagery evokes a sense of artificiality and uniformity and suggests a superficiality and lack of authenticity in the Planners' efforts to shape the environment
  - Cheng has used this metaphor to highlight how the Planners prioritise appearance and style over substance as the image of the "shining teeth" implies that all underlying flaws or imperfections within the landscape are hidden

- Cheng uses medical terminology such as "anaesthesia, amnesia, hypnosis" to describe the methods employed by the Planners to manipulate and control as they seek to numb, erase or manipulate the collective memory of the population:
  - The terminology used evokes a sense of detachment and disconnection from reality, highlighting the ways in which the Planners attempt to shape public perception and memory to fit their own agenda

- The phrase "they have the means" suggests that the Planners have the power to shape the landscape according to their desires:
  - This implies a sense of power and authority that the Planners have as they have access to resources and technologies that enable them to control and manipulate the environment

- The idea that the Planners have the ability to make history "new again" suggests their desire to erase and gloss over the negative aspects of history to create a sanitised and idealised version of the past:
  - The Planners seek to create a sense of continuity and renewal, erasing any traces of the past that do not fit their version and visions of the future

- While the language Cheng has used seems positive on the surface, the images created are not intended to be pleasant or comforting:
  - Cheng has used language to highlight the clinical and detached actions of the Planners in the pursuit of their goals

- Cheng's use of vivid imagery and evocative language serves to highlight the ways in which the Planners seek to shape public perception, memory and experience to fit their own agenda, regardless of the consequences:
  - Cheng offers a critique of the superficiality, manipulation and control that he is suggesting is

“The piling will not stop.

The drilling goes right through

the fossils of last century.”

Translation

- The speaker describes how the Planners will not stop no matter what they have to drill through or destroy

Cheng’s intention

- The persistent and **unyielding** nature of construction is emphasised through the first line:
  - It suggests an ongoing and never-ending process of building and development, highlighting the relentless nature of growth and expansion
  - The phrase “will not stop” underscores the sense of **inevitability** and determination driving the Planners, emphasising the **futility** in attempting to halt or resist the process

- The imagery of the drilling going “right through the fossils of last century” conveys a sense of disregard for the historical and cultural heritage of the urban environment:
  - The use of the word “fossils” suggests a sense of history and significance, implying that these remnants of the past hold cultural value
  - Therefore, the act of drilling through them signifies a lack of respect and appreciation for the past as the Planners prioritise progress and development over preservation
  - The reference to fossils could also be linked to fossil fuels, which are used to build and run cities

- The mention of “fossils of last century” carries a symbolic significance as it represents the remnants of a bygone era that is being overpowered by the relentless march of progress:
  - The Planners are undermining the historical and cultural legacy of the past

Lines 24–27

“But my heart would not bleed

Poetry. Not a single drop

to stain the blueprint

of our past’s tomorrow.”

Translation

- The speaker makes a personal response and puts themselves in direct opposition to the Planners and reflects on the emotional impact of the Planners’ actions and creation

Cheng’s intention

- This stanza is powerful as the poet is using their own voice to give their personal response to what the Planners have done:

- The phrase "but my heart would not bleed" suggests a lack of a connection to the changes taking place:
  - This implies a sense of **desensitisation** or resignation over the actions of the Planners

- "Blood" is significant as it could symbolise a person's life force and so Cheng could be implying that the urban landscapes have resulted in loss of life:
  - However, blood could also symbolise an individual fighting or giving their life for their beliefs or country
  - It could therefore highlight how detached the individual now feels to their environment due to the expansion of the urban landscapes

- Cheng laments the inability of his heart to produce poetry in response to the urban landscape:
  - The imagery suggests that the poet's creativity has dried up as they are unable to produce the emotional depth and inspiration necessary for poetry

- Through these lines, Cheng critiques the relentless march of progress and development that prioritises efficiency and productivity over creativity and uniqueness:
  - The inability to produce poetry suggests a loss of humanity and connection to the natural world as a result of the Planners' actions
  - This highlights the **dehumanising** effects of urban development, which can stifle creativity and emotional expression in its relentless pursuit of growth and expansion

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Your exam question will ask you to explore how a poet presents a certain theme within their poem. It is therefore a good idea to begin your answer using the wording of the question and summarising what the poem tells us about that particular theme. This demonstrates that you have understood the poem and the poet's intention. For example: "Cheng presents the negative impact of modernisation and its effects in 'The Planners' by suggesting that modernisation comes at the tragic cost of erasing history and culture."

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into three separate sections – form, structure and language – it is always best to move from **what** the poet is presenting (the techniques they use; the overall form of the poem; what comes at the beginning, middle and end of a poem) to **how** and **why** they have made the choices they have.

Focusing on the poet's overarching ideas, rather than individual poetic techniques, will gain you far more marks. Crucially, in the below sections, all analysis is arranged by

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Avoid "technique spotting". This is when students use overly sophisticated terminology unnecessarily, and sometimes inaccurately, without any analysis of how the technique in question contributes to the overall effect of the poem or deepens our understanding.

Knowing the names of sophisticated literary techniques will not gain you any more marks, especially if these techniques are only "spotted" and the poet's intentions for this language are not explained. Instead of technique spotting, focus your analysis on the reasons **why** the poet is presenting their ideas in the way that they are: what is their message? What ideas are they presenting, or challenging?

Form

This poem is written in three stanzas of varying lengths.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Control and manipulation	The poem is written in **free verse** and so does not follow a regular metre or rhyming scheme	By choosing free verse, Cheng may be attempting to mimic nature rather than the mathematical calculations he references in the poem. It could be argued that Cheng is attempting to challenge the stifling and rigid structure that the Planners use when designing the urban landscapes

Structure

The lines in the poem are broken into varying lengths, with the first stanza containing the most lines and the last stanza containing the fewest.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Control and manipulation	The poem consists of three	The poem critiques the desire for

	stanza one, to ten lines in stanza two, to only four lines for the final stanza	emphasising the loss of individuality. The varying stanza sizes could be seen as challenging this theme and highlighting how creativity thrives when it does not follow a set pattern
	The poet uses caesura in the first line of the poem: "They plan. They build."	Cheng may have done this deliberately to imitate the building blocks that the Planners would use to build their cities. The use of full stops creates a rigid and controlled structure to reflect the mathematical and technical methods the Planners use
	Cheng frequently uses enjambment	While enjambment is usually used to create a sense of free-flowing movement, it could be argued that Cheng has used it in 'The Planners' to represent the **insatiable** greed of the Planners and the constant expansion of the urban landscapes
The pitfalls of modernisation	The poem is divided into distinct sections, each focusing on different aspects of the urban landscape and what the Planners have done in order to maintain order. The final stanza is the speaker's personal opinion on the impact of the Planners' schemes	Cheng explores the pitfalls of modernisation in the poem and **laments** the destruction of natural landscapes and cultural heritage in the name of progress and advancement. The poem reflects on the loss of traditional ways of life and the erosion of cultural identity in rapidly changing environments, highlighting the emotional and

Language

Cheng uses a number of literary devices in the poem to highlight the sinister and clinical ways the Planners have changed the landscape.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
The pitfalls of modernisation	Repetition has been used throughout the poem in a number of ways. Anaphora, which is the repetition of words or phrases at the beginning of lines, has been used, such as "they have"	The use of the word "they" creates distance between the reader and the Planners, and makes them seem more sinister and dangerous. As a result, it seems that they do not have society's best interests at heart
	The writer also uses **parallelism** such as "they plan. They build"	
	The writer also uses the personal pronoun "they" when referring to the Planners and uses the possessive pronoun "my" once in the final stanza	The repetition of the pronouns emphasises how the Planners are detached and alienated from the rest of society

	stanza two to compare the Planners to dentists performing operations. Words such as "gaps", "plugged" and "drilling" are used as well as "anaesthesia" and "amnesia" to draw parallels between dental procedures and the methods the Planners use.	arrogance of those who seek to control and manipulate the natural world for their own purposes. The poem suggests that the relentless pursuit of progress and development can lead to a disregard for cultural heritage, highlighting the dangers of unchecked ambition and arrogance

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Try not to separate "language", "form" and "structure" into three separate elements you need to include in your answer. To achieve top marks, you need to include an **integrated** exploration of the themes and ideas in your chosen anthology poem, and focus on the relevance of the method used by the poet to the ideas in the poem.

This means it is better to structure your answer around an exploration of the ideas and themes in the poem, based on the focus of the question, commenting on elements of language, form or structure that contribute to the presentation of these themes, rather than simply listing all of the key methods you think should be covered when writing about poetry (with no analysis or exploration of their relevance to the themes and ideas). Stay focused on the task, and then choose your comments based on the focus of the question.

Understanding the text

All questions in the IGCSE encourage an informed, personal response, which means that it is not enough just to know the poem itself really well; you also need to develop a sound understanding of the themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events depicted. While context is not explicitly assessed in the IGCSE, an awareness of background information as relevant to the main themes in the poem can help you to

themes that Cheng explores in 'The Planners':

- The pitfalls of modernisation
- Control and manipulation

The pitfalls of modernisation

- Cheng was born and raised in Singapore:
  - Although the poem is set in a nameless city, it is likely that Cheng has taken inspiration from Singapore

- Singapore is known as a fast-paced urban city, which has made significant advancements in urban landscaping:
  - It is therefore possible to draw parallels between Singapore and the city in the poem

- The first six lines present the city as pristine and perfect with the Planners using precision and mathematics to create a functional and aesthetic city
- However, the speaker finds the city rigid and monotonous with the neat lines and perfectly built structures suffocating and lacking creativity
- The speaker claims that the Planners have effectively erased all history and culture from the city and replaced it with uniformity and precision
- The use of the extended metaphor also compares the Planners to dentists who have used "anaesthesia, amnesia" and "hypnosis" to erase the rich history of the city from the memories of society and replace it with their version of perfection
- The speaker claims that the city is full of "possibilities" and with the "grace of mathematics" but they do not view this as a positive thing:
  - The speaker feels that these "possibilities" have stripped the city of self-expression and natural growth

- The Planners have erased what they consider "the flaws" and replaced them with "rows of shining teeth" so that "history is new again":
  - However, the speaker feels that this **erasure** has resulted in a loss of beauty and inspiration

Control and manipulation

- The poem shows how human beings such as the Planners attempt to control and manipulate nature into something unnatural:
  - Instead of the Planners allowing nature to thrive, they aim to **distort** and overpower nature and, as a result, "the seas draw back and the skies surrender"

- The theme highlights the power dynamics at play in urban planning, as well as the consequences of unchecked authority and manipulation:
  - The Planners use "mathematics" and "grids" to create a regimented and uniform system when it comes to building urban landscapes

- The speaker then goes on to list the methods that the Planners use in order to manipulate and make society conform to their plans:

and power they possess

- The speaker emphasises that the Planners "build and will not stop" which implies that there is no limit to how much the Planners will build:
  - By stating that "the sea draws back and the skies surrender" the speaker could be implying that nature also been overpowered by the Planners and their attempts at modernisation
  - However, it could also be taken literally to mean that the urban landscapes are growing so rapidly that it is literally making the sea draw back due to buildings being constructed and the skies being invaded by inventions such as bridges, skyscrapers and planes
- The reference to drilling into "fossils" could also suggest the erasure of history but it could also literally refer to the use of fossil fuels, which has led to climate change
- The poem critiques the need for control and manipulation and highlights the destructive nature of humanity

Examiner Tips and Tricks

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed revision guides on Paper 1 Section A, which include "What the Question is Asking", "How to Get Full Marks" and a full, annotated model answer. It is important to remember that no marks are given for any comments you might make in your answer to any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem and the focus of the question

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